changes in the set-up of the house to pre-empt any intruder from finding out anything suspicious. He asked Vijayan to put up photo frames of Rajiv Gandhi, MGR and Jayalalithaa on the walls, get some musical instruments and place them around, and add more calendars of Hindu deities that local Tamils worshipped. Sivarasan didn't want to take any chances. He had also asked Bhaskaran to arrange for another house. But no one was willing to rent Sri Lankans any place.

Sivarasan might have kept his cool on the exterior but his mind was not at rest. An instruction that came from Jaffna through a wireless message was a big jolt to him. Pottu Amman had instructed Nero and Sivarasan to stop messaging Jaffna as all their messages were being intercepted by the Indian security agencies and decoded. Earlier, Sivarasan had succeeded in confusing the Indian security forces with his messages, but not any longer. The Indian navy, the Coast Guard, the Tamil Nadu coastal police and the SIT were now working together and kept strict vigil on any coded communication. Jaffna turned down Sivarasan's request for more time to figure out an escape route from the country.[9]

The Congress party's medical cell head, Dr Chokalingam, took Anirudhya to the house in Kodungaiyur, where he met the Anglo-Indian Mantels who lived next door to Sivarasan. 'Had the SIT acted fast they would have caught the gang,' regretted Robert Mantel, a retired employee of the Indian Railways. His wife Esylen added that she was always sure of the tenants' identity, but nobody listened to them. The house was Sivarasan's base, from where he kept in touch with Jaffna through his VHF device.

Esylen claimed that Vijayan and his wife would often drop in for a chat. But slowly their attitude changed. Robert Mantel recalled, 'Sivarasan used to ride a Kawasaki. He would often wear jeans, a khadi kurta and a Panama cap while riding it. He was not too particular about hiding his glass eye until it became an identifying mark. And maybe when my wife asked Selvi about his eye, Sivarasan became suspicious. And he would always carry a